

Not quite jazz - improvisation games

At Jazz North we are keen to reinforce the idea that improvisation is just another musicianship skill rather than a specific jazz skill. Improvisation is used in many musical genres including folk, music from the global majority and in the world of contemporary classical music. We would encourage all tutors to use improvisation as a creative task or a game to play in their various teaching situations and to focus on their student's journey rather than their destination.

With this in mind, here are some improvisation games to try with your students.

1. 3 is the magic number

Ask your students to play the highest note that they can on their instrument - this does not have to be the highest that the instrument is actually capable of. If they can't all play the same one it also does not matter - just encourage your students to listen to what the notes sound like together. Do they sound dissonant or concordant? Do they like the sound or dislike it?

Now ask them to make up a rhythmic pattern on that note. Ask your students to play them one at a time, then see if they can copy each other's rhythm? Try combining the rhythms together.

Ask your students to play the lowest note that they can on their instrument (same rules apply as with the highest note and repeat the activities)

Ask your students to play their favourite note on their instrument (same rules apply as with the highest note and repeat the activities)

Once your students have their 3 notes you are going to play a game where everyone plays their 3 notes out of time and in any order but they must only play each pitch once. They do not have to play them one after the other or using the same rhythm e.g. they could play a long first note, wait for 4 beats, play a short second note immediately followed by a longer third note. The game is only finished once everyone has played their 3 notes. This activity encourages your students to listen carefully and make choices about where they are going to place their notes.

If you can sit down in your lesson then you could try getting your students to do this activity with their eyes closed to really help focus their listening skills.



2. Take your note for a walk

In this game either the tutor or a confident student acts as the conductor and the rest of the group follows their hand movements to dictate the pitch, dynamic and speed of notes played. This could also be done by drawing lines on a whiteboard (like a graphic score) and following the shapes made.

3. Journey from A to B

In this game a starting note and a finishing note are chosen (could be by the tutor or student). The task is then to improvise a route from note A to note B. It could be a direct route or something more meandering. Example

The example shows musical notation on a five-line staff in 4/4 time. The first measure, labeled 'Start', contains a single quarter note on the first line (F4). The second measure, labeled 'End', contains a single half note on the second line (G4). A double bar line follows. Below this, two alternative routes are shown, starting from measure 5. The 'Direct route' shows a sequence of quarter notes: F4, G4, A4, B4, and then a half note on C5. The 'Meandering route' shows a more complex path: F4, G4, A4, B4, C5, B4, A4, G4, F4, E4, D4, C4, B3, A3, G3, F3, E3, D3, C3, B2, A2, G2, F2, E2, D2, C2, B1, A1, G1, F1, E1, D1, C1, B0, A0, G0, F0, E0, D0, C0, B-1, A-1, G-1, F-1, E-1, D-1, C-1, B-2, A-2, G-2, F-2, E-2, D-2, C-2, B-3, A-3, G-3, F-3, E-3, D-3, C-3, B-4, A-4, G-4, F-4, E-4, D-4, C-4, B-5, A-5, G-5, F-5, E-5, D-5, C-5, B-6, A-6, G-6, F-6, E-6, D-6, C-6, B-7, A-7, G-7, F-7, E-7, D-7, C-7, B-8, A-8, G-8, F-8, E-8, D-8, C-8, B-9, A-9, G-9, F-9, E-9, D-9, C-9, B-10, A-10, G-10, F-10, E-10, D-10, C-10, B-11, A-11, G-11, F-11, E-11, D-11, C-11, B-12, A-12, G-12, F-12, E-12, D-12, C-12, B-13, A-13, G-13, F-13, E-13, D-13, C-13, B-14, A-14, G-14, F-14, E-14, D-14, C-14, B-15, A-15, G-15, F-15, E-15, D-15, C-15, B-16, A-16, G-16, F-16, E-16, D-16, C-16, B-17, A-17, G-17, F-17, E-17, D-17, C-17, B-18, A-18, G-18, F-18, E-18, D-18, C-18, B-19, A-19, G-19, F-19, E-19, D-19, C-19, B-20, A-20, G-20, F-20, E-20, D-20, C-20, B-21, A-21, 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